

ON THE DEEP COLD

Winter is not a colour problem.

The traditional Japanese calendar does not hand you four seasons. It hands you seventy-two. The year is cut into twenty-four *sekki*, and each of those into three *kō* of roughly five days — small, exact, observed. We are writing this during *daikan*, the great cold: the week the old almanac marks as "butterburs bud beneath the snow." Even in the hardest cold, something is already turning.

That is the winter instinct worth keeping at home. A cold room is rarely cold because of temperature. It is cold because it was decorated in cool greys and bright whites and left there — clinical, correct, joyless. The fix is not more colour. It is warmer neutrals, fewer of them, and light low enough to forgive the dark.

The Danes have a word the design magazines wore out: *hygge* — older than its candle-and-blanket reputation, rooted in an Old Norse sense of refuge. The Japanese have *seijaku*, the stillness that is composed rather than empty. This issue lives between them. Warmth, held in restraint.

